

KS3 Music — 4 Chords (unit guide)

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Key stage & curriculum

KS3 Music (typically Year 7–9). Performing, composing and listening around the I–V–vi–IV progression.

Pedagogy: Musical Futures–style informal learning (peer coaching, classroom band roles) and the public Axis of Awesome–style “four chords” classroom concept. Original CCDesigner outlines only.

Learning outcomes

- Play I–V–vi–IV fluently with a steady pulse in a group.
- Maintain an independent part (bass, chords, rhythm or melody).
- Improvise / compose a short hook or song sketch on the progression.
- Identify the progression in familiar songs and describe its effect.

Lesson outline (5 lessons)

1. Find the four chords — recognise and play I–V–vi–IV with a steady pulse.
2. Play as a band — layered parts (bass, chords, rhythm, melody).
3. Melody over the loop — improvise and refine a hook.
4. Mash-up / song sketch — verse–chorus structure on the progression.
5. Share, reflect, next steps — perform and evaluate with KS3 vocabulary.

Classroom tips

Peer coaching, classroom band roles, and short recorded feedback keep the focus on pulse and ensemble balance.

Further reading: musicalfutures.org (public organisation site).